Submission[1] to the Governance and Administration Select Committee on the Emergency Management Bill.

Community Resilience First – The Newlands Work as a Scalable Pilot Aligned to the Government Inquiry

INTRODUCTION

We seek improvements to the Bill that strengthen the level of engagement with and enabling of communities to build resilience for the first 7 days. We acknowledge that building community resilience economically, socially and culturally requires a range of organisations and networks to operate together, so that relationships and community resilience can underpin and strengthen capability and coordinated response rather than ad-hoc response to an event. This is what we are trying to enable in Newlands in a financially sustainable way , not requiring taxpayer or ratepayer funding.

For risk to be managed holistically requires a transparent understanding of who is carrying which risks and their respective capabilities to do so to an acceptable level. If everyone thinks that another part of the emergency management system (community, essential service providers, local and central government) understands or is carrying a portion of the risk, it is better to identify gaps early than find out after an event that there is insufficient response and incomplete recovery.

1. Purpose of Revised Formal Submission

This revised submission does not change the substance, evidence, or recommendations of our original submission. The revisions have been made to respond directly to the Committee's questions on 11th February regarding how the submission connects to the Emergency Management Bill. In particular, we have:

- made explicit reference to the purpose of the Bill in clause 3,
- clarified how the Newlands work gives practical effect to enabling communities to achieve acceptable levels of risk under clause 3(c), and
- explained how clause 94 (community and iwi engagement) is necessary but not sufficient on its own to achieve community readiness without sustained enablement and monitoring.

These changes are intended to assist the Committee by clearly mapping the existing submission to the Bill's intent and structure. No new policy positions are introduced.

The submission also responds directly to the findings of the Government Inquiry into the Response to the North Island Severe Weather Events, and seeks governance-level recognition

[1] Includes formal submission on 23 January and supplementary submission made on 15 February

and support for the Newlands work as a scalable pilot demonstrating how community readiness and early-phase risk management can be operationalised in practice.

2. Relationship to the Purpose of the Bill

Clause 3 of the Bill states that the purpose of the Act is to support the social, economic, cultural, and environmental wellbeing and safety of the public. Of particular relevance to this submission are:

- clause 3(a): promoting and improving the sustainable management of hazards
- clause 3(c): enabling communities to achieve acceptable levels of risk, including through identifying, assessing, and managing risks, communicating about risks, and implementing cost-effective risk reduction
- clause 3(d): planning and preparing for emergencies and for response and recovery
- clause 3(e) and (f): coordinated local and national emergency management planning and activity

The Newlands community resilience work provides a practical, place-based example of how communities can make a key contribution to achieve these purposes at neighbourhood scale whilst reducing the load on emergency services and improving other social wellbeing outcomes at the same time. It demonstrates how communities can be enabled to actively manage risk, reduce harm, and protect wellbeing in the period before and during emergencies, rather than remaining passive recipients of assistance from a centralized system that might arrive late and potentially be overwhelmed.

3. Background and Context

The Government Inquiry into the Response to the North Island Severe Weather Events demonstrates that New Zealand's emergency management system is not fit for purpose in the face of increasingly frequent and severe events. The most significant failures occurred before and during the early days of response, when communities were largely left to cope on their own. To some extent this is understandable, since the early days emergency management focus is on search and rescue, assessing and preparing for a centralized response at scale. However, there is a way to improve this situation.

The work underway in Newlands, Wellington, has been designed in direct response to this reality and is strongly aligned with the Inquiry's findings regarding early system failure, readiness gaps, and the critical role of communities and iwi in achieving better outcomes.

4. Key Issue: Community Resilience Before Disaster Resilience

A central insight from the Newlands work is that disaster resilience cannot be built directly or in isolation. Strong community resilience is an essential foundation for disaster resilience.

Communities that are connected, informed, practiced, and trusted are able to better respond collectively in the first five to seven days of an emergency, before regional and national systems are fully mobilised. This capacity directly supports the Bill's objective of enabling acceptable levels of risk under clause 3(c). However, whilst acceptability of risk is an admirable aspiration, it requires transparency on hazard exposure and who is carrying direct or residual risk. Only once this is transparent can potential gaps be identified and acceptability to respective parties considered relative to other economic / social / cultural and environmental stress factors.

The Inquiry's evidence supports this view. Many people experienced the official response as absent or inadequate during the critical first 24–48 hours. Where outcomes were stronger, it was because community and iwi networks were already active, not because the formal system arrived sooner. The Newlands work is deliberately designed around this reality.

5. Approach: Designing for the First Seven Days

The Newlands work assumes that during large-scale or multi-region events, government systems cannot immediately meet all local needs. Planning therefore focuses on ensuring communities can self-organise, support one another, and reduce harm during the first five to seven days. This goes compliments but goes beyond the current design of CDEM Hubs, and improves functional community cohesion during emergencies and every day.

This approach gives practical effect to clauses 3(c) and 3(d) of the Bill by treating community readiness as a foundational standing capability rather than an event-triggered response.

This is operationalised through:

- sustained investment in local relationships and trust,
- clearly defined and trained community roles (Board and Operations, Community Connectors, Mentors), in addition to and complimentary to CDEM Hub functions in that they serve the community outside of emergencies and support or reduce the loading on the Hub during emergencies
- ongoing mentoring and professional supervision rather than ad-hoc mobilisation,
- shared awareness of local hazard exposure, local vulnerabilities (physical and socio-economic), assets, people at risk and local capabilities, and
- simple, practiced mechanisms for neighbour-to-neighbour support and communication.

These elements directly address the Inquiry's finding that many communities were unaware they had a role, lacked plans, and were unprepared to act collectively.

6. Relationship to the Formal Emergency Management System

The Newlands work is not designed to replace councils, Emergency Management Committees, or national agencies. Rather, it strengthens the overall system by ensuring that communities are functioning before the system is under stress.

When communities can respond early and coherently, councils and emergency services are better able to focus on search and rescue, infrastructure assessments, logistics, coordination, and planning recovery at scale. This supports the Bill's intent in clauses 3(e) and 3(f) to enable coordinated and integrated emergency management across local and national levels.

The Newlands work gives practical effect to the Inquiry's recommendation to recognise people and communities as an active partner in emergency management alongside local, regional and central government and essential infrastructure/service providers.

7. Community Engagement and Clause 94

Clause 94 of the Bill requires Emergency Management Committees, when developing regional emergency management proposals, to engage with disproportionately affected communities and to engage with and involve iwi and Māori.

This submission supports that requirement and notes that clause 94 is an important signal of Parliament's intent to strengthen community readiness and equity.

However, the Newlands experience demonstrates that engagement alone does not enable communities to achieve acceptable levels of risk. Consultation without sustained support, clear roles, and ongoing capability building does not translate into readiness or reduced harm during emergencies.

The Newlands model shows how the intent of clause 94 can be strengthened in practice by moving from engagement to enablement , thereby supporting the wider purpose of the Bill in clause 3(c), however as we indicated in our introduction and was discussed at oral submission we consider that monitoring and reporting capabilities and outcomes is valuable to increase community trust and emergency management authorities' level of commitment. For example, we have been monitoring our communities' vulnerabilities and outcomes using the Treasury's Living Standards Framework aligned with the National Resilience Strategy. We would be happy to share the findings and potential learnings if this would be of interest, and it is also included in the attached overview document. Our intention is for a University Research paper to be published mid 2028 informed by the October 2027 Annual Survey results as part of the demonstration of improved outcomes and sharable learnings.

8. Readiness as a Social Investment

The Inquiry identifies lack of readiness investment as a root cause of system failure. The Newlands experience demonstrates that readiness is not only technical but fundamentally social.

Equipment, plans, and platforms are important, but without trust, participation, leadership, and shared responsibility, they will not perform under pressure. By building community resilience first, disaster resilience becomes durable, repeatable, and adaptive, particularly in the context of repeated events and long recovery periods.

This directly supports the Bill's objective of sustainable hazard management and ongoing risk reduction, particularly when paired with transparent hazard and vulnerability data and a framework for transparent expectations and responsibility toward managing the collective risk.

9. Financial Sustainability and Scalability

A distinguishing feature of the Newlands work is that it has been designed to be financially sustainable and scalable. From April 2027, we anticipate the model will be self-funding for use by other suburbs, generating sufficient revenue to cover ongoing operational costs whilst maintaining charitable trust status. This ensures quality, safety, and consistency as the model scales, while reducing long-term reliance on short-term grants and ongoing pressure on council and central government budgets.

10. Evidence and System Learning

The Newlands work incorporates annual community surveys, independent research, and publicly reported findings (scheduled for 2028). This provides the evidence base and system assurance that the Inquiry identifies as lacking nationally, enabling informed decisions about policy, investment, and replication. We have previously engaged with WREMO and would welcome the opportunity to work with government agencies and other community resilience pilots (if they exist locally or internationally), to refine the model / framework through shared learnings and co-design.

11. Meeting Local Needs with Local Capability: An Illustrative First-Hour Earthquake Scenario

To assist the Committee in visualising how the Bill's purpose in clause 3(c) and 3(d) can be operationalised in practice, we have included an illustrative scenario describing the first 45 minutes following a severe earthquake in a Wellington suburb. Please refer page 9.

This scenario demonstrates the sequencing described in Section 4 of this submission: strong community resilience is a prerequisite for effective disaster resilience.

In the scenario, a resident is seriously injured during an earthquake and requires urgent assistance. Because the suburb has previously invested in community resilience — strengthening social cohesion, building trust across cultural and economic groups, identifying informal leaders, and developing shared awareness of local vulnerabilities and capabilities — the neighbourhood is able to activate an applied disaster resilience model immediately.

A Community Connector is known and trusted. Local skills have already been mapped. Roles are clear. Communication mechanisms are practiced. A builder, a first aider, a psychological first aider, and a resident with suitable transport capacity are mobilised within minutes. The local medical centre is informed in advance of arrival.

The formal emergency management system is not replaced. Rather, it is supported.

This capacity did not emerge during the earthquake. It was the downstream result of sustained relational investment in ordinary time, followed by deliberate implementation of a light but structured disaster resilience model.

The scenario illustrates how local needs can be met by local capability during the first five to seven days of an event — precisely the period identified by the Government Inquiry as a systemic weakness.

It is provided not as advocacy but as a practical demonstration of how clauses 3(a), 3(c), and 3(d) can be given effect at neighbourhood scale.

12. Recommendations

That the Governance and Administration Committee:

1. **Formally recognise community resilience as a pre-requisite to achieving the Bill's purpose**

   Explicitly acknowledge in the Bill or accompanying guidance that **community resilience is a prerequisite to achieving the objectives in clauses 3(c) and 3(d)** in practice. Building community resilience — economically, socially, and culturally — requires coordinated effort across local government, iwi, community organisations, essential service providers, and residents. Where relationships, trust, and shared understanding are established in advance, coordinated response is strengthened and reliance on ad-hoc mobilisation is reduced.

   Effective risk management also requires transparency regarding:

   - hazard exposure,
   - residual risk,
   - which party is responsible for carrying or managing particular risks, and

- whether each party has sufficient capability to do so.

Without this clarity, gaps may only become visible during or after an event. Early transparency strengthens both accountability and preparedness.

2. **Strengthen Clause 94 from engagement to enablement**

   Amend or clarify Clause 94 to move beyond consultation toward **active enablement, facilitation, and monitoring of whole-of-community readiness**, particularly for the first five to seven days of self-reliance during major events. In addition to engagement with disproportionately affected communities and iwi, the Bill should encourage Emergency Management Committees and councils, to the extent practicable, to:

   - facilitate clear articulation of roles and responsibilities across authorities and communities.
   - support community organisation that strengthens everyday wellbeing as well as emergency readiness.
   - promote transparency regarding risk allocation and capability; and
   - monitor and report on community readiness capability and outcomes over time.

   Engagement alone does not produce readiness. Sustained enablement and visible monitoring increase trust, clarity, and shared responsibility.

3. **Support evidence-based learning, pilots, and scalable models**

   Encourage the use of community-led pilots, including the Newlands initiative, as part of council and national assurance, learning, and continuous improvement in emergency management policy.
   Structured pilots provide:

   - practical demonstration of how clauses 3(a), 3(c), and 3(d) can be operationalised at neighbourhood scale.
   - evidence on what strengthens early-phase response capability.
   - insights into financial sustainability and scalability; and
   - a mechanism for iterative system learning aligned with the Government Inquiry's recommendations.

   Formal recognition of such pilots within national learning and assurance processes would strengthen the Bill's intent to promote sustainable hazard management and improved readiness over time.

12. Conclusion

The Emergency Management Bill seeks to promote sustainable hazard management, enable acceptable levels of risk, and strengthen coordinated preparedness, response, and recovery across local and national systems.

The evidence of the Government Inquiry into the North Island Severe Weather Events demonstrates that New Zealand's emergency management system is most vulnerable in the early phase of major events — precisely when communities are largely required to rely on their own capability.

The Newlands work has been intentionally designed in response to that reality. It demonstrates that disaster resilience cannot be built in isolation. It is the downstream result of sustained investment in community resilience — in relationships, trust, clarity of roles, shared awareness of risk, and practiced neighbour-to-neighbour support.

This submission does not seek to replace or diminish the formal emergency management system. Rather, it seeks to strengthen it by recognising communities as active partners in risk management and early response, and by encouraging a shift from engagement alone toward enablement, transparency, and monitored capability over time.

If the Bill is to achieve its purpose in practice, communities must be enabled to understand risk, share responsibility appropriately, and act coherently in the first five to seven days of an event.

The Newlands pilot offers a practical, financially sustainable, and scalable example of how this can be operationalised at neighbourhood scale, while supporting councils, Emergency Management Committees, and national agencies to focus on their core functions during periods of stress.

We respectfully invite the Committee to consider modest but important refinements that would strengthen the Bill's alignment with the Inquiry's findings and embed community resilience as a foundational component of New Zealand's emergency management system.

We have provided an overview of the Newlands work starting on page 11 The associated Business Case is available for the Committee's information if useful. We also provide our history since 2010 in relation to disaster resilience, including repeated attempts to secure local and central government support: https://newlandrg.weebly.com/our-history.html

Ngā mihi,

Rodney Barber

Leader-Newlands Resilience Group https://newlandrg.weebly.com

Donor and Chair-Aotearoa Community Resilience Network, a registered charitable trust

ILLUSTRATIVE SCENARIO: FIRST 45 MINUTES AFTER A SEVERE EARTHQUAKE

(Demonstrating the Sequencing of Community and Disaster Resilience)

At 9:18am on a weekday, a magnitude 7.4 earthquake strikes Wellington. Power fails. Telecommunications are unreliable. Emergency services are immediately overwhelmed.

In a residential suburb, a resident runs to the nearby Community Connector's home. His partner is trapped beneath a displaced concrete retaining block. She has sustained a serious leg injury and is bleeding heavily. Their two preschool children are terrified. Aftershocks continue.

There is no certainty of ambulance arrival in the immediate term.

What Enabled the Response

The speed and effectiveness of the response in this scenario did not begin with a disaster plan. It began years earlier with Community Resilience.

Phase 1: Community Resilience (Foundational Work in Ordinary Time)

Prior to the earthquake, the suburb had invested in strengthening:

- Neighbour-to-neighbour trust
- Cross-cultural inclusion and social cohesion
- Relationships between residents, schools, local businesses, faith communities and informal leaders
- Awareness of vulnerable households
- Everyday mutual support practices

This phase was relational, not operational. It focused on connection, belonging, and legitimacy. As a result:

- Residents knew one another by name.
- Informal leaders were recognised and trusted.
- Practical skills within the neighbourhood were visible.
- There was social licence for coordination in a crisis.

Only because this foundation existed could the next phase function.

Phase 2: Disaster Resilience (Applied Capability)

Once relational strength was established, the suburb implemented a light but structured Disaster Resilience model, including:

- Identification of Community Connectors
- Mapping of local skills (builder, first aider, psychological first aider, 4WD owner)
- A simple coordination platform
- Role clarity for the first 72 hours to seven days
- Alignment with formal emergency services and local medical providers

When the earthquake strikes, this capability is activated immediately.

The Community Connector sends a high-priority alert through the local platform to:

- A qualified builder to assess and safely lift the concrete block
- A trained first aider to control bleeding and stabilise the injury
- A psychological first aider to support the children
- A resident with a 4WD vehicle to prepare for transport

Responses are confirmed within minutes.

The builder assesses structural safety before lifting.
The first aider stabilises the injury and monitors for shock.
The psychological first aider supports the children to reduce acute trauma escalation.

The Community Connector contacts the local medical centre to advise that a stabilised casualty is en route.

Once safely extricated, the injured woman is transported by 4WD to the medical centre for immediate triage.

Emergency services may arrive later — but the critical early window has already been addressed.

Why This Matters

The capacity demonstrated in this scenario was not created during the earthquake.

It was the downstream result of:

1. **Community Resilience** — building social, cultural, and economic strength in ordinary time.
2. **Disaster Resilience** — operationalising that strength into coordinated capability.

If disaster systems are introduced without first strengthening community cohesion, coordination tools alone are unlikely to function effectively.

However, where foundational resilience exists, a disaster resilience model can ensure that:

- Local needs are identified rapidly
- Local capabilities are activated immediately
- Psychological and practical needs are addressed together
- Medical transport and communication are coordinated
- The first seven days are stabilised at neighbourhood scale

In effect, the community is not waiting passively for the system. It is acting in alignment with it.

Community resilience is the enabling condition. Disaster resilience is the applied expression.

The ability to meet local needs with local capability in the first seven days is the measurable outcome of investing in both — in the correct sequence.

OVERVIEW

26th January 2026

Our vision is to enable residents to connect and build trust as a key enabler for community resilience ; be disaster resilient; and speak with our voices into decisions.

Huia e huia, tangata kotahi!
Huia, your destiny is to bring everyone together!

The huia bird is known for its friendly ability to draw everyone together. These birds are known for their enduring relationships, committing for life to their partner. The male huia has a shorter straight beak while the female huia has a longer curved beak. This represents the taonga (treasure) of diversity and that, although we may look different and work differently, we are united in our humanity.

The Newlands community is pleased to launch a two-year pilot to implement a locally designed "Coordinated Community and Disaster Resilience" Model designed to demonstrate the value of enhanced community connectedness as an essential foundation for resilience.

Led by the Newland Resilience Group, under the governance of the Aotearoa Community Resilience Network Trust, the pilot puts into action the strategy they developed, which was informed by the results of annual community surveys since 2019 to map the community's vulnerabilities and capabilities. See the last page for a summary of the results. The survey insights clearly demonstrated that the first step in improved disaster resilience would be to improve community connectedness.

In developing the business case and the Model we engaged with 30 local social, economic and cultural leaders including Newlands Primary, Newlands Kindergarten, Newlands Intermediate, Newlands Health Centre, Baptist Church, Anglican Church, Newlands Scouts, Paparangi Scouts, Ngā Hau e Whā o Paparārangi, Logan' Hindu Temple , Newlands Paparangi Progressive Association, Newlands Fire and Emergency, Newlands Community Centre, Northern Ward Local Councillors , and the Local MP

We also engaged 5 wellington networks such as Volunteer Wellington, Greater Wellington Neighbourhood Support, Timebank Wellington, Citizens Advice Bureau and the Wellington Regional Emergency Management Office.

We have also secured support (when funding is secured) from a resident APP developer, the New Zealand Mentoring Foundation, Massey University, a book Author, a social media organisation, Nga Taonga, and Teaho who "weave together clinical expertise, mātauranga Māori, and lived experience to promote oranga/wellbeing."

We also currently have 70 volunteer residents interested in being part of what we are trying to establish.

It stands to reason that improved connectedness enables more robust disaster resilience, and it is also critical for empowering the community to be able to speak up to influence decision-making, which is the key to driving overall public value long term.

For example, the Newlands project to improve connectedness as the first step in improved disaster resilience not only offsets what local and central government might have to invest in themselves to support disaster resilience, but also generates wider benefits such as reduced pressure on publicly funded mental health services.

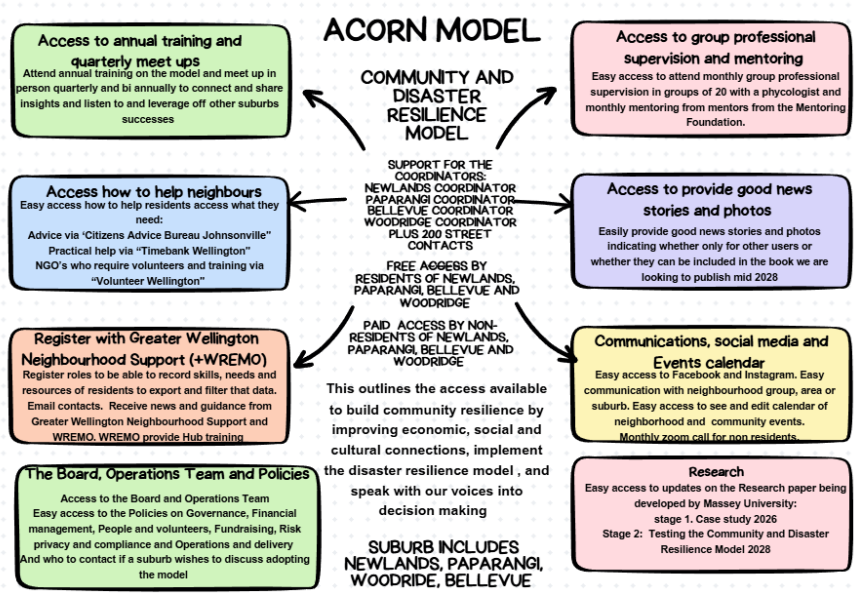
We are seeking residents to be part of building resilience from April 2026 to be better connected, prepared to respond to emergencies and proactive in speaking into decision-making. Residents will invest around 3 hours pw voluntarily to be:

- on the Board of 6 or on the Operations Team of 6, or
- one of the 200 Community Connectors who love gathering people to strengthen social, economic and cultural cohesion and help connect residents with the support and services they need from existing service providers, or
- one of 66 Mentors who enjoy supporting each member of the Board and Operations Team plus one mentor for each of 4 Community Connectors.

They will receive

- Quarterly training A six-hour training session on the ACoRN model and a 30-page manual on how it works
- Quarterly meet ups There will be quarterly meet ups of all volunteers
- Monthly mentoring Six one-hour mentoring sessions (monthly) provided by Newlands based Mentors through Mentoring Foundation partnership.
- Monthly Group Professional Supervision. Commencing early 2027 all Community Connectors will have access to monthly group professional supervision to ensure they have access to the support they need for their wellbeing.
- Guidance in facilitating a group for building Community and Disaster Resilience, and Speaking with Our Voices

- ACoRN APP**.** the source of knowledge for the Board, the Operations Team , the Community Connectors, the Mentors, residents and others, all with tiered access. Here is a concept design:



The model will be implemented from April 2026 to late 2027 in a phased way:

- From April 2026 we will start building **Community Resilience** with residents who enjoy bringing neighbours together to strengthen connection, trust, and social repair. These residents will act as respectful connectors in the community, leading with humility, active listening, service, and good judgement rather than control. The focus is on responding constructively to areas of harm, exclusion, and unfairness by fostering care, fairness, and a consistent, supportive presence within the community.
- From November 2026 Start implementing the **Disaster Resilience Model** we have developed
- From April 2027 start implementing **Speaking with our Voices**

We need $272,800 from April 2027 to March 2028 for the leader $60,000 social media $30,000, APP development $25,000, Research stage 1 $24,800, Popular Articles $8,000, Mentoring $125,000 . We are in the process of applying for this funding from DPMC NEMA, Wellington Community Fund and the NZ Community Trust, Gray-Dalley-Chenery, Tindall Foundation and Foodstuffs. As soon as we receive advice from these funders, we will let you know.

We have secured proposals for each of our 5 requests but have not secured a competitive quote for the following reasons:

1. Social media: We would prefer to use Howie as we have used him since 2021 after a competitive tender in 2021.
2. APP development: We would prefer to use a Newlands resident who has provided his PixelBoost proposal.

3. Research stage 1: The Joint Centre for Disaster Research at Massey University Wellington have shown strong interest and commitment to the research.
4. Popular Articles: John Hawken has been very involved in the development of the business case as a technical writer
5. Mentoring: I am a volunteer mentor with the Mentoring Foundation and value the way they manage the mentoring programme with volunteer mentors.

In mid-2026 we will apply to the Lottery Fund (Community Organisation Grants Scheme and the Lottery Community Project Fund) for a further $166,000 for April 2027 to March 2028 for the leader $60,000, social media $30,000, Research stage 2 $60,000, and /Popular Articles $16,000.

From April 2027 the annual ongoing costs of operation will be approx. $500,000pa for

- WREMO related first aide training of approx. $100,000 pa. We will support Greater Wellington Neighbourhood Support in their funding applications,
- the support for the 200 volunteer community connectors of approx. $400,000. The model will be financially self-sustaining for use by other suburbs to cover these costs.

All residents in the suburb of Newlands, Paparangi and Woodridge will benefit from this work by experiencing a stronger community, being more confidently prepared to respond as a community to disaster, and more confidently influence government and council decision-making processes. This will be measured by our annual community survey each October and potentially studied by a University research paper to be published mid-2028 together with a book of stories how residents' lives have improved. Our modelling indicates forecast savings from reduced demand on publicly funded services (e.g. mental health) of up to $4 million per year for Newlands, Paparangi and Woodridge alone. We're also documenting refinements to our model to create a scalable model for other communities, requiring less upfront investment from them to take a similar approach and further magnifying the overall public benefit. A free licence to adopt the Model would be issue as a bespoke copyright licence for community safety, research integrity, public trust, and our stewardship responsibility.

We have a business case which we are happy to forward should you need it

Rodney Barber
Leader-Newlands Resilience Group
https://newlandrg.weebly.com
https://www.facebook.com
Donor-Aotearoa Community Resilience Network, a registered charitable trust
Phone 0274788061

Annual survey results

The 2025 Annual Community Survey provides a snapshot of community resilience, disaster preparedness, and civic engagement. The survey questions use the indicators in the Treasury Living Standards framework aligned to the National Resilience Strategy. Overall, the results show strong personal and social foundations, alongside clear vulnerabilities in economic security, collective action, disaster readiness, and institutional trust. These results have been similar each year from 2019.

Community Resilience

- **Economic wellbeing** is mixed. Residents report strong basic life skills and capabilities, but experience lower confidence in employment security, declining paid work hours, and dissatisfaction with income. This indicates resilience at an individual skill level, yet vulnerability in economic stability and opportunity.
- **Environmental wellbeing** is generally positive, with high satisfaction in access to the natural environment. Moderate confidence exists around water safety for recreational use. However, residents express low confidence that land is being used optimally, highlighting concerns about long-term environmental stewardship and planning.
- **Social wellbeing** is a key strength. High levels of independence, social connection, and subjective wellbeing are evident, alongside moderate strengths in safety, work–life balance, mental wellbeing, and access to support during crises. A notable vulnerability is low participation in helping others and supporting community initiatives, suggesting strong personal wellbeing but weaker collective engagement.
- **Cultural wellbeing** shows strong individual foundations, with high capability in first-language use and a strong sense of belonging in Aotearoa New Zealand. However, participation in cultural activities and the sharing of cultural knowledge is low, pointing to untapped cultural richness within the community.

Disaster Resilience

Disaster preparedness remains a significant vulnerability. Only half of residents are prepared at home for a disaster, and just 10% are involved in a neighbourhood support group. As a result, it is unclear whether homes and communities could effectively cope during the first 3–7 days following a major natural disaster, before formal government assistance is available.

Speaking With Our Voices

Civic participation is strong at the ballot box, with high voter turnout in both the 2022 general election and the 2023 local elections. Trust in the New Zealand Police sits at a moderate level. However, trust in Parliament and local councils is low, indicating a disconnect between citizens and decision-making institutions and reinforcing the importance of community-led engagement and local public-value decision-making.